THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

Paris Branch: 28 rue des Acacias 75017 PARIS
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Patron:
Her Majesty The Queen

Hon. President:
H.B.M. Ambassador

Incorporated by Royal Charter

NEWSLETTER November 2011

Dear Members,

Please find enclosed your AGM package for this year. We hope to see as many of you at Rue des Acacias on 8th December at 18h30.

Any member who is fully paid up with their subscription may put their names forward for any position on the Committee. Anyone wishing to propose a member for the Committee **must** obtain the persons agreement that they do not object to their name being put forward.

STOP PRESS : Due to interest from members wishing to have a Christmas Dinner, we have decided to hold the Christmas lunch on Tuesday 13th December, 12h15 for 12h30 as previously stated in the last Newsletter. The Christmas Dinner will be held on Thursday 15th December at 19h30. Hence only one lunch and one dinner. Just before the Dinner the Tombola Draw will take place. We have heard that some of you feel our prizes are not worth the ticket price. We would just like to remind you that all prizes are donated to us and therefore if you would like better prizes, why not donate something yourself. Joan Hicks will be happy to receive any gifts from you. We do write to outside companies for prizes, should you know of any we might be able to contact, please let either Joan Hicks or Janet Warby have the name, address and telephone number of the company or persons to contact . We hope you will support this years Tombola which will round off our 90th Anniversary year.

Please let Joan Hicks know if you would like to attend either the lunch or dinner. The price is €32 which includes Welcome Kir, Lunch/Dinner and Coffee. Wine can be bought from the bar either by the bottle or glass. Please fill in and return the reply slip below to Miss Joan Hicks, 6 rue des Petits Prés, 78810 Feucherolles. If you need to cancel your booking, please do so a week in advance of the date for either lunch or dinner. No cheques will be returned if we do not have prior notice. Our cooks will have bought the ingredients for the Christmas festive lunch or dinner.

Reply Slip for Christmas Lunch/Dinner

I ---------- would like to reserve ---------- places for the Christmas lunch/dinner*

I enclose my cheque made payable to 'The Royal British Legion' for €----------

My telephone number is ----------

Signed ----------

*Please state either lunch or dinner

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

NOTICE OF THE ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING 2011

To be held at 28, rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris
on Thursday 8th December, 2011 at 18h30

All members, may attend and speak at the A.G.M. Only those members who have paid their subscription by Thursday 1st December may vote. Please find attached the ruling on Proxy Voting, as drawn up by the Branch Committee, following instructions from the 2001 A.G.M.

Nominations for the Committee must be made by a Member and seconded. The consent of the nominees must be obtained. All nominations must be returned to the Branch Secretary before December 1st .

Members may make proposals for consideration at the A.G.M., provided that they reach the Branch Secretary before December 1st .

The minutes of the previous A.G.M., are attached together with the accounts. Please remember to bring them with you to the A.G.M., together with this notice.

AGENDA

a) The Exhortation

b) Apologies for absence

c) Minutes of the previous AGM

d) Matters arising from the Minutes

e) Chairman's Report on the Year's work

f) Treasurer's Report

g) Welfare Report

h) Election of Officers and Committee

i) Resolutions of which notice has been given

j) Any Other Business

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING 2011

NOMINATIONS

Chairman _____

Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Vice-Chairman _____

Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Hon. Treasurer _____

Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Hon. Secretary _____

Proposer _____ Seconder _____

COMMITTEE NOMINATIONS

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

Name _____ Proposer _____ Seconder _____

PROXY VOTING

As from September, 2005 the Privy Council have endorsed the Single Membership Charter Motion. This now entitles all Members to vote and, if elected or appointed, to hold office or be a member of any Committee, provided that their Branch subscription is no more than 3 months in arrears. Therefore, at Branch Annual General Meetings now being held, all Members may vote and may be nominated for Officer or Committee posts at all levels. In the UK RBL rules do not provide for proxy voting, but the Charity rules of the French Loi 1901, which apply to the Paris Branch, may supersede the RBL ruling. In the case of the Paris Branch, where many members live some considerable distance from Paris, and who cannot attend the relevant meetings, such members may arrange for their proxy vote to be held by another member. A member so wishing to arrange for a proxy must personally obtain the approval of another member who is prepared to act as proxy, and then ensure that the duly completed proxy form is sent to the Secretary by 1st December, 2011. Members may hold no more than two proxies each.

PROXY FORM

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

A.G.M. 8th DECEMBER, 2011

I _____, Paris Branch Member, will be absent from the Branch AGM

2011, and hereby nominate _____

as my proxy at that meeting, in accordance with the above Proxy Voting Rules.

This form should be sent to the RBL Paris Branch Secretary at 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris, to arrive no later than December 1st , 2011.

Signed _____

Dated _____

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
THURSDAY 9th DECEMBER, 2010

FOR YEAR 1st OCTOBER 2009 – 30TH SEPTEMBER 2010

The Paris Branch Annual General Meeting was held at 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris, on Thursday 9th December, 2010 at 18h30. The Chairman, Mr. R. Thorn, invited all members to stand for the Exhortation & Silent Tribute. The Chairman asked all to remember in the silence, John Konirsch, Paddy Leniston, John Leck, Stanley Edwards, Bill Teasdale, Dora Pearce and David Portsmouth who had died in the last year.

There were thirteen members present with four guests which included the Chairman of Nice-Monaco Branch, Cdr. Michael Healy, Micky van Teckelenberg also from the Nice-Monaco Branch, Mr Chris Fewkes, Auditor of the Paris Branch and Mr. Richard Hallows. The Chairman welcomed them all.

Apolgies for absence : Apologies were received from Mesdames M. Taylor, Mann, Hicks, Hopkins, Gilhooley, Bateau-Clubb, Armengaud, Burkard, Bean, Messrs. Allbeury, Corrigan, Robinet, Peridi, Howard, Renouard, Warby, Wicker, Macleod, Liberman, Alton, Cockle, Scott, Rev. Philip Mounstephen, Rev. Varty Mr & Mrs Riols, Mr & Mrs Archambault and Mr. & Mrs Zomerplaag. We had received 15 proxy votes from amongst these members.

Minutes of the Previous AGM : The Chairman asked if the minutes of the 7th January, 2010 AGM could be signed and if so were there any matters arising. As there were none the minutes were signed as a true record and dated.

Chairman's Report : The Chairman began his report by thanking all who had turned out for the AGM. He said the numbers were low due to the age of some of our members and the inclement weather we were having at the present time. The Chairman then proceeded to give his report.

Welfare : Welfare will always be our Raison d'être. We continue to contribute Euros 10,000 per annum to the British Charitable Fund. Our beneficiaries receive allowances totalling approximately 5 times that amount. Our Welfare Officer, David Bean, will present his report later. Charles Spencer-Bernard has volunteered to join the team of Welfare case-workers alongside David and Elizabeth Bean. Thanks to our case-workers for a job well done.

Poppy Appeal : The Chairman said he would like to thank Joyce Gilhooley and her helpers, Janet & Roger Warby, George Mutch and Midge Hopkins for all they did in making the Appeal a success. This year has been a challenging one for Joyce as she had to undergo serious heart surgery. We hoped she would soon be back to full health.

Ceremonies since the last A.G.M. :

Rekindling of the Flame : We had as our Guest of Honour at the Arc de Triomphe, H.E. Mr Shafkat Saeed, Ambassador of Pakistan. We followed this ceremony with a reception at the Clubhouse where the Ambasador presented the Branch with a Ceremonial sword and the Military Attaché presented us with a shield. There was a run on the orange juice that night.

Notre Dame 2010 : There was an exceptionally high turnout for the 2010 Service of Remembrance. We must thank our Chaplain, Rev. Philip Mounstephen, for his Order of Service, and for giving the sermon. We thank in particular S/Sgt Twining, who brought 8 uniformed and civilian ushers from Portsmouth. We managed to secure once more the services of the excellent piper and Coldstream cornet player who played for us this year. Both musicians played to perfection. Thanks to Rev. Philip Mounstephen, Roger & Janet Warby, Chief Usher David Bean and his team of Edwin Gould and Mark Yates.

Churchill/de Gaulle Statues : On 22nd April jointly with Mémoire et Espoirs de la Résistance (M.E.R.), we laid wreaths at the statues of Sir Winston Churchill and Général Charles de Gaulle.

Service at RAF Memorial, Maisons-Laffitte on 25th April.

Ceremonies at and near Vernon (Eure) on 26th August : The Chairman attended a ceremony to commemorate the Liberation of the town on that date in 1944 by 6 Infantry county regiments, 1st Worcesters, 4th Somerset Light Infantry, 4th & 5th Wiltshires and the 5th Cornwall Light Infantry.

Ceremony at Montreuil-sur-Epte on 29th August : The Chairman attended a ceremony to commemorate the anniversary of the death of three British soldiers of 13th/18th Hussars, killed on that date in that village on reconnaissance duty. A monument had been erected by the Commune on the site where their tank was attacked, and this was unveiled by M. le Maire and the Chairman, who was representing the Light Dragoons Regiment. The official photographs of the ceremony are being sent to the Regiment's archives. An estimated crowed of 200 turned out in a village whose population is 250. A very moving ceremony.

Pedal to Paris on 5th September : The Paris Branch was represented at the Annual cycle rally Pedal to Paris, culminating in the laying of a Poppy Wreath at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier by the National Chairman, who had taken part in the rally. Thanks to Col. Jacir for his help in organising the ceremony at the Arc de Triomphe.

British School of Paris : Service of Remembrance on 8th November : The Chairman attended this Service and addressed the school on the origins and work of the R.B.L., and on the origins of the Poppy as our emblem.

Battlefield Visit : The planned visit to the Tunisian battlefields was cancelled due to lack of numbers. We had costings based on 20 participants, but sadly only 9 registered. We suspect that the cost of the package might have been the main reason for the low response. Accordingly discussions are currently taking place with Col. Oliver Warman on an appropriate destination nearer to Paris. A visit to the Somme is pencilled in for Spring 2011.

Membership : The Paris Branch numbers have continued to drift downwards. This is a widespread trend throughout The Royal British Legion. However to consolidate our move to rue des Acacias, in 2011 we are determined to concentrate on drumming up additional members here in Paris, where we judge there is a fund of good-will towards us in the British Community. Mailing costs of Branch papers to members are naturally high, and we continue to use e-mail to communicate with members wherever possible; the percentage of e-members is now around 60%. Thanks to Mark Yates for his many hours of administrative work.

Social events in the last RBL year : Christmas Lunch on 16th December, 2009, Christmas Mess Night on 18th December, 2009, Standard Bearers' and New Members' Cocktail on 9th April 2010. Poppy Coffee morning in the

Ambassador's Residence on 2nd November, 2010. On 4th December, 2009, we held a Portes Ouvertes for members of the British Community. Les Clack and Trish read a selection of War Poems. This event was planned to attract

new members and also new business from associations wishing to hire our premises for their meetings and receptions. This remains an essential part of our current mission statement. Thanks must go to Joan Hicks, Janet Warby , Carmen Thourot , Vicky Millet and David Bean for their help.

Co-propriété : Thanks to Jack Wicker for representing us most effectively on the Co-propriété Committee He and the Chairman attended the AGM of Co-propriétaires of rue des Acacias on 5th July.

House Manager : At the last AGM Tony Bennett agreed to be our new House Manager, but he did not wish to have a seat on the Committee. Monthly lunches will recommence in 2011 with a wide range of cuisine. Our warm thanks to Tony Bennett for catering for these monthly Club lunches. The project to hold a regular weekly lunch was dropped because of low attendances.

Fund-raising : The Sweepstakes and Tombola will be reported on in the Treasurer's report later. The Chairman said how grateful we were to members for their faithful support which the Treasurer appreciates enormously. The Chairman thanked all members who supported us in this way.

Relations with the British Embassy : The Ambassador is our Patron in France, H.M. The Queen remaining our National Patron. Many thanks to Sir Peter Westmacott, Air Commodore Michael Brzezicki and Wing Commander Graham August for their continued support.

Branch Statutes : The Royal British Legion in London asked us last year to prepare new statutes in a form which as uniform for all overseas branches. Following that exercise we proceeded to take the opportunity to update our French-language Statutes which had remained unchanged since 1994. The resulting draft text prepared by an Anglo-French law firm Ashurst, is presented to you today , we propose to seek acceptance of these statutes later in the Agenda.

Branch Committee : The Chairman said he would like to thank his hard-working officers and committee. He said many hours of voluntary work were put in by our Secretary and Treasurer and without them this branch would grind to a halt. The Chairman said that the Treasurer had decided that after 20 years he would not seek re-election to the post of Treasurer. However, we have not yet been able to find a replacement and so Mr Blanchard has said he will continue in an acting capacity and will coach the incoming Treasurer. It is proposed that the Committee will hold a Mess Night in the New Year at which Mr & Mrs Blanchard will be the guests of honour when we shall dine him out.

The future : 2011 marks the 90th Anniversary of the Paris Branch and the Royal British Legion as a whole. We are planning a Dinner/Dance in May or June. The selected date will be circulated at the earliest opportunity. We look forward to the challenges of the future with confidence. We hope to encourage more new members from the British Community and beyond.

The Royal British Legion in London wished to see a District set up in France. In Legion-speak, this means the equivalent of a County Committee in the UK. A District has two certain powers, most of which are administrative, with two key powers, a) to call an Annual District Conference of the Branches; and b) to attend Branch meetings and to examine the Branch books.

Districts already exist in Germany and Spain. A meeting was held in September of the Chairmen of French branches. The delegates from London presented us with the apparent advantages of forming a District. All branches were requested to invite their membership to vote on this resolution. If there were a majority of branches in favour then a district would be formed in 2011. We shall deal with this later under Resolutions.
The Chairman said that he had sent a letter of solidarity and our congratulations on a job well done to the Chairman of Wotton Bassett Branch. This Branch have quietly paraded their standard together with Regimental Association standards in the town of Wotton Bassett, when the coffins of our soldiers killed in Afghanistan return to nearby RAF Lyneham. We had hoped that Wotton Bassett would be present at our annual 4th August ceremony at The Arc de Triomphe. Unfortunately due to age and cost, the Chairman of Wotton Bassett said his Branch would not be able to make the trip this year but, hoped to do so in 2011. Our Chairman said he had met his opposite number in Paris in July. Should the Wotton Bassett Branch come over next year perhaps we could assist them financially by offering to billet their members in our private homes.

Finally, the Chairman said that no matter what we once were, be it Brigadier or a Bombardier, an Air Commodore or an Aircraftsman, a Ship's Captain or the Ship's Cook, everyone mucks in to do the job in hand and we are as one. So that when you enter the Clubhouse you leave your baggage at the front door. The Chairman said he thanked all for their attention.

Treasurer's Report : In the Treasurer's absence, the Chairman read out the following. Our operating expenditure exceeded our income by 1,484 euros, mainly because we did not benefit from the interest received last year on the money invested following our property sale. Last year our income from operations exceeded expenditure by 705 euros. Net fund-raising income was up by 3,102 euros with a significant decrease in subscription income and a significant increase in donations and other fund-raising activities. Our total cost of recurring operations was up by 5,291 euros over last year, mainly due to increased premises costs of 972 euros, increased administration cost of 879 euros and the decline in interest income of over 2,500 euros.

On the Balance Sheet our net assets stood at 550,463 euros, and the Administration Fund cash position was 39,018 euros, down considerably over 2009 following payment of the last part of the renovation costs for the new premises.

On the Poppy Appeal Fund donations of poppy sales were up by nearly 1,000 euros over the last year. Relief payments made to the British Charitable Fund wer 11,000 euros and other welfare payments of 500 euros. We show a net excess of income over outgoings for the year of 537 euros and our accumulated funds stood at 2,888 euros.

Acceptance of these accounts were proposed by Mr. Edwin Gould and seconded by Mr. David Bean

Welfare Report : Mr. Bean reported that we had had a relatively quiet year. One case was still ongoing. We have cases with the British Charitable Fund and on that note Mr. Bean said he would like to thank the BCF for all their work and assistance they give to us and our welfare cases. In the current economic climate, we may find ourselves called upon to give financial assistance.

Election of Officers & Committee : The Chairman reported that Mr. O.G. Longley, CBE, MC, had agreed to be our Hon. President. The Chairman asked Mr. Longley to read the names of the nominees for the positions of the Officers.

Chairman	Roger Thorn
Vice-Chairman	Jack Wicker, OBE
Acting Treasurer	David Blanchard
Secretary	Janet Warby

The following were elected to the Committee : Miss J. Hicks, Mme N. Riols, Miss V. Millet, Messrs Bean, Cockle, Davey, Edwards, Gould, Dumont, Spencer-Bernard and Yates.

The following are invited to be ex-Officio Members on our Committee : Col. D. Jacir, Mr. G. Scott, Mme G. Corrigan and Mme P. Levalleur. Rev. Philip Mounstephen is our Branch Chaplain, Mr. C. Fewkes is Branch Auditor and Miss J. Gilhooley is the Poppy Appeal Organiser.

The Officers were voted into office and the Committee were elected en masse. This was proposed by Mr. Les Clack and seconded by Mr. Robert Gillespie.

Resolutions :

1. The Chairman explained the Statutes to the meeting, and after some minor alterations, the Statutes were accepted. These were proposed by Mr. Charles Spencer-Bernard and seconded by Mr. Mark Yates.

2. The Chairman then went on to explain in depth the concept of forming a District in France. The resolution was :

   "This branch is in favour of the proposal for the Royal British Legion to form a French District".

In the debate which followed it was realized that there were certain advantages to the branches in France, but it was also recognized that no information had been received regarding the cost to The Royal British Legion of the formation of a French District. In the show of hands that followed the debate, the Resolution was defeated unanimously.

Any Other Business : Mr. Longley said he would like to thank the Chairman for all his hard work in maintaining a tight ship.

There being no further business, the meeting was closed at 19h55.